Brimstone and Marmalade

By Aaron Corwin

NOTE: The humor from this selection comes from the characterization and voice qualities of the characters. Go big and have fun!

NARRATOR: Mathilde didn't want a demon. She wanted a pony.

MOTHER: Ponies are expensive. How about a nice little demon instead?

MATHILDE: *(stamping her foot)* I don't want a demon! Demons are ugly and creepy and they smell bad!

FATHER: We'll see.

MATHILDE: *(to audience)* When a grown-up said "we'll see," it really meant "never." Peter Voorhees brought his demon to school. It was scaly and slobbery, not sleek and pretty like a pony. How could anyone think that a demon was better?

INTRODUCTION

When I was little, I desperately wanted a pot-belly pig – But my parents in all of their wisdom gifted me with BURBLES – the goldfish. BURBLES didn't last very long, and I remember hosting my own little funeral service as we flushed him to his watery resting place.

BURBLES was followed by a succession of other small creatures – 4 more fish, a hamster, and a bunny. At least I wasn't condemned to own a pet rock!

In this fantasy selection, Mathilde doesn't get the pony she wants; but a miniature demon named Ix'Thor. Take that, BURBLES.

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FOR EDUCATION

NARRATOR: The day before Mathilde's birthday in September . . .

PRINCIPAL: Mathilde, your parents called. Your grandmother is picking you up.

MATHILDE: Nana's here for my birthday? Nana always brought presents. (to Nana) Nana!

NANA: Look at you! My little Matty-Patty's all grown up!

MATHILDE: *(giggling)* Where are we going?

NANA: You didn't think I'd come all this way and not bring you a present, did you? The sort of present you'd better pick out for yourself!

NARRATOR: Mathilde could scarcely believe it. After all this waiting, she was finally going to get a pony of her very own. But when the car stopped, it was in front of a store covered in steel plates and the air smelled just a little bit like rotten eggs. It was very dark inside.

MATHILDE: This isn't a pony store! This is a demon store! I don't want a demon! I want a pony!

NANA: When I was a girl, we had a Belgian Muncher on the farm. Smart as a whip if you train 'em right. You know the best thing about demons? They're great for convincing parents that little girls are responsible enough to take care of a pony. If you prove you can take care of a demon. . . then we can see about that pony. *(Nana and Mathilde enter the store)*

SHOP KEEPER: Well, hello there! Are you here for a new demon?

NANA: Yes. It's her birthday.

SHOP KEEPER: *(to Mathilde)* I see! What sort of demon were you looking for?

MATHILDE: The kind with the pretty eyes and the long, shiny mane!

NANA: *(sighing heavily)* That's a pony, dear.

MATHILDE: Well, that's what I want!

SHOP KEEPER: Oh, I think I have just the one for you. *(he pulls out a small glass cage)*

NARRATOR: The demon inside didn't have a long, shiny mane. It didn't have any hair at all, just a tiny, black hooded robe. Its eyes were two red stars that twinkled in the darkness of its hood like Christmas lights.

SHOP KEEPER: He's a Miniature Dark Lord.

NANA: *(shaking her head)* A Dark Lord? I thought they had great big horns!

SHOP KEEPER: Normally. But this poor little guy was born without any. All the other Dark Lords rejected him.

MATHILDE: *(feeling a connection with rejection)* What's your name?

IX'THOR: *(raising his arms over his head)* I AM IX'THOR, MASTER OF THE VENOMOUS PITS OF KARTHOOM! BOW BEFORE YOUR MASTER!

SHOP KEEPER: How about that! He told you his name first thing. He must really like you.

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MATHILDE: *(pouting)* Well, I don't like him . . . *(IX'THOR is deflated, lowers his arms and hangs his head)* But I guess he'll do.

NARRATOR: Mathilde had a hard time sleeping that night. Her thoughts kept drifting toward the pony she would have someday. How long would she have to take care of a stupid demon, anyway?

MATHILDE: *(sleeping . . . she snores lightly)*

IX'THOR: *(pokes MATHILDE on the chin, she swats him away, but he continues to poke)*

MATHILDE: *(awakens with a start)*

IX'THOR: KNEEL BEFOR YOUR MASTER, MORTAL!

MATHILDE: Aaaaaah! Mom! *(IX'THOR squeals and quickly hides)*

MOTHER: How did he get out of his cage? *(looks around the room for the demon)*

MATHILDE: *(also looking, she sees a dark shape dart under her bed and grabs a flashlight)* He's right here! *(she reaches under the bed and grabs his little body)* I've got him!

IX'THOR: *(slashing has her hand with his claws)*

MATHILDE: EEEEEEE! *(abruptly drops him, crying)* I hate demons! I want a pony!

MOTHER: Oh, sweetie. It's just a tiny little cut. He was just scared, that's all. You have to be careful with animals. When they're scared they lash out. They don't know any better.

MATHILDE: *(belligerently)* I don't want him in my room!

NANA: *(clearly disappointed)* I'm sorry. I'll take him back to the store tomorrow.

MATHILDE: *(she remembers her pony and backpedals)* Wait! I didn't mean it. He can stay.

MOTHER: This is your last chance. If you say you don't want him one more time, we'll give him to someone who does.

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NARRATOR: [The next day – Mathilde's Birthday]

MATHILDE: *(excited)* There was cake! Chocolate with white frosting and candy sprinkles. And presents! A camera and a unicycle and *(sadly)* eleven different kinds of **TOY** ponies. *(to the kids at the party)* I did get another present . . . You want to see him? *(she leads them to her bedroom)* You have to turn the lights down. *(as she dims the lights)* He doesn't like light.

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BECKY: It's not a snake is it?

MATHILDE: Shhh! It's not a snake. *(She lifts the cover from the cage)*

IX'THOR: WELCOME TO MY DOMAIN. FOOLS! DID YOU THINK YOU COULD DEFEAT ME?

ROBBY: Wow! That's cool!

MATHILDE: *(with a real smile of pride)* He's a Dark Lord.

ROBBY: Does he do any tricks?

IX'THOR: BOW BEFORE ME!

MATHILDE: You shouldn't actually bow. That just encourages him.

BECKY: It's just a demon. What good is a demon who doesn't even do anything? I bet he bites.

IX'THOR: FOOLISH MORTALS. NOW BEHOLD MY TRUE POWER! *(he waves his arms and emits a bust of fire from his hands)*

ROBBY: WOW! You said he didn't do any tricks!

IX'THOR: GIVE ME YOUR SOUL AND I WILL GRANT YOU LIMITLESS POWER.

MATHILDE: Mom says I can't have limitless power until I'm older. But you can have a grub soul.

NARRATOR: [Mathilde takes out] a small, softly glowing ball, about the size of a pea from the big plastic bag Nana had bought. The bag said things like "Nutritionally Balanced" and "Now with extra innocence for a health glow!"

IX'THOR: EXCELLENT *(racing to the side of the cage, he stands with his arms outstretched)* IX'THOR ACCEPTS YOUR SACRIFICE. *(he devours the pellet)* NUM NUM NUM!

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NARRATOR: [Soon it was Halloween] A witch came to the house with a black pointy had, a broomstick, green skin and a big, warty nose.

MATHILDE: Nana!

NANA: *(in a big witchy voice)* Happy Halloween! Eee-hee-he-hee! How's my little angel?

MATHILDE: I'm not an angel *(raises the hood to her robe and speaks in an Ix'Thor voice)* I'm a Dark Lord. Bow before me, mortals!

NANA: *(feigning fright)* Oh, my! I think I felt the earth tremble for a moment.

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MATHILDE: *(mimicking IX'THOR)* Excellent. It is just as I have foretold. *(She picks up a traveling crystal ball and holds it up)* Ix'thor's coming with us! He says fear keeps the peasants in line.

NANA: Mathilde . . . you know not everything Ixthor says is a good idea, right?

MATHILDE: *(rolling her eyes)* Well, duh!

IX'THOR: MWA HA HA! NOTHING CAN STOP US NOW!

MATHILDE: *(mimicking IX'THOR)* I'll take my revenge when I rule the world. Mwa ha ha.

(Mathilde starts to walk toward the street, trips and falls forward. The crystal ball holding Ix'Thor launches from her hand and tumbles through the air into the street – there is the sound of squealing brakes and then shattering glass)

MATHILDE: No! *(she races to Ix'thor)* Ix'thor! Please!

IX'THOR: THIS . . . CANNOT . . . BE. I AM IN . . . VINCIBLE . . .

******* At the demon store *******

NARRATOR: [The family rushes Ix'thor to the demon store, hoping the shop owner can save him]

FATHER: Demons are pretty strong, right? Almost impossible to kill?

SHOP KEEPER: Dark Lords are weaker in direct sunlight. Much weaker. I did all I could.

MATHILDE: *(crying)*

MOTHER: Oh, sweetie. It wasn't your fault. There was nothing anyone could have done. *(more sobbing from Mathilde)* Father and I were talking to Nana. If you still want one . .

MATHILDE: *(defiantly)* I don't want a pony! I want Ix'thor. But I can't have him back, can I?

MOTHER: No, I'm sorry.

MATHILDE: Then . . . can I get a pony with glowing red eyes and crush the skulls of my enemies beneath his flaming hooves?

MOTHER: *(laughing)* One with glowing eyes!

MATHILDE: *(in her best Ix'thor voice)* Excellent! It is just as I have foretold . . .

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